

The Missing Page

The Backhoe Broadcast

Story Sleuths / Ages 12-15

Case 01: The Untitled Ending

The final page has disappeared from the Idea Lab archive. A note remains: Four clues. Four words. Find the sentence and I will return the page.

How to play

Keep this free casebook beside the game. Read the exhibits, solve four clues, and collect four code words. Enter the recovered sentence in clue order to open the final page.

Every answer needed for this free case is in these pages. No purchase and no outside research are required.

Use Exhibit A for the first three clues and to discover the shift needed in Exhibit B. Write the message from the surviving wall exactly, but capitalization and punctuation do not matter.

Ages are suggested reading trails. Readers can choose the trail that suits them. Reading with a parent or another reader is welcome.

The mystery framing and case notes are fictional game material. Quoted story excerpts retain their story context.

EXHIBIT A

The Harness - Chapter One: Good Luck With That

Kevin Dean Rosenkrans. Selected opening from the October 2, 2026 web sampler. This selection contains no profanity; the full novel is written for adults.

Black.

Not darkness exactly.

Darkness implied someplace for light to be absent from.

This was less generous.

Nothing.

Then, somewhere in it, machinery woke up.

A diesel engine coughed once, caught, and settled into the low industrial growl of something large enough to damage a building without particularly meaning to.

Then came the warning.

BEEP.

Silence.

BEEP.

Silence.

BEEP.

On the third one, Kevin saw the cursor.

Thin.

White.

Blinking in empty black space.

The beep came again.

The cursor blinked with it.

Again.

Blink.

Again.

Until the black around it began to acquire edges.

Glass first.

Then concrete.

Then floodlights.

Then the skeleton of a building large enough that calling it a building felt inadequate.

The world assembled itself around the cursor as though somebody had been waiting for Kevin to notice it.

Open Forge.

Or what remained of Open Forge.

Half the campus looked unfinished.

The other half looked like someone had finished it and then reconsidered violently.

Construction lights threw hard white pools across broken pavement. Temporary fencing leaned against permanent fencing that had stopped being permanent sometime earlier in the evening. A section of glass façade was missing. Orange barriers surrounded a trench no one had bothered to explain.

And in the middle of all of it, a backhoe was reversing through what used to be a security gate.

BEEP. BEEP. BEEP.

Kevin Rosenkrans stood twenty yards away holding a paper cup of coffee.

Older Kevin Rosenkrans.

Much older.

His knees knew it.

His lower back knew it.

His right shoulder had apparently spent the intervening years compiling a legal brief against him.

But the basic architecture remained.

Six-foot-four.

Large frame.

The posture of a former offensive lineman who had long ago stopped needing shoulder pads for strangers to decide not to crowd him.

Gray had won most of the negotiations with his hair.

His face carried the additional lines of a man who had spent several decades hearing sentences that began with technically.

He watched the backhoe take another bite out of history.

Then looked at the wall.

A section had survived demolition for no obvious structural reason.

Across it, in large painted letters:

GOOD LUCK WITH THAT.

Kevin took a drink of coffee.

Cold.

Of course.

He had the strange feeling that the universe had been setting up this joke for years and was annoyed he hadn't laughed yet.

"Very funny," he said.

Nobody asked what he meant.

This was either because they understood him or because, after enough time around Kevin, determining which remark belonged to which problem became unnecessary.

EXHIBIT B

Signal memo

A fictional case note written for this game; it is not part of the novel.

The archive receiver found this message beside the broadcast:

WUXVW HYLGHQFH

The sender shifted every letter forward through the alphabet. The number of places is the numbered warning on which Kevin first sees the cursor. To read the message, reverse that shift. A wraps around after Z.

A shift of 1 turns A into B. A shift of 3 turns A into D. To undo a shift of 3, D becomes A.

Alphabet: ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ

Your detective notebook

Return to the game to check your answers. The game supplies a code word for each solved clue.

1. First contact

Exhibit A - the warning before the cursor

On which numbered warning does Kevin first see the cursor?

Answer: _____

Recovered word: _____

2. The world assembles

Exhibit A - the edges of the black space

What three things acquire edges first? Enter them in their story order.

Answer: _____

Recovered word: _____

Your detective notebook / continued

3. The surviving wall

Exhibit A - the painted letters

What four words are painted on the surviving wall?

Answer: _____

Recovered word: _____

4. The intercepted message

Exhibit B - signal memo; also Clue 1

Decode WUXVW HYLGHQFH. Undo the forward alphabet shift you found in Clue 1.

Answer: _____

Recovered word: _____

The final sentence

Place the four recovered words in clue order, then enter the sentence in the game.

Continue the story

These openings are an invitation to keep reading. The free case ends completely when you recover the page.

Credits

Stories and studio: Kevin Dean Rosenkrans / DEAN + DON SOL. Mystery design and original children's pilot: Don Sol with Dean. Casebook edition 1.0, October 2, 2026.